

The Humanist Movement

(aka The Humanist Subversion)

The Humanist Movement is a small group of intellectuals who have latched on to the new philosophy of "Humanism". Humanism is a new theory which states that Mankind is at the centre of existence, and as such, Humans are the single most important force in the universe. The emphasis is placed on the material world, and Humanity's place in it. Rather than the Saintly Faith's preoccupation with the afterlife, Humanists believe that entering into the Abyss' Valley of Darkness at death is actually an individual choice made by the person. A Humanist, therefore, chooses not to enter into the Valley of Death, allowing the soul to dissipate into the universe, much like the material body dissipates into the ground. This theory of choice is unproven, but it leads to the additional belief that the Human choice is far more important than the Saintly choice.

On Death and Dying

A proper Saintly funeral must be performed in order for a soul to enter the Valley of Darkness in the Abyss. The body must be prepared and properly buried, and the correct rite and spells must be performed in a funeral. Failure to either prepare and bury the body correctly, or to perform the appropriate magical rites, will trap the soul in the Prima Plana in undeath.

Travel and Communication Between the Planes

There is no communication or travel possible between the Abyss and the Prima Plana with Celestia. Celestia is closed, abandoned and mostly forgotten. If there is a method for communication, or of access, it has long been forgotten. Finding this is key to the motivation of both Celestials and Infernals. (Celestials hope to find it, and thus be able to return to their proper domain, while Infernals, which are corrupted Celestials, hope to find it in order to conquer and enslave all of existence.)

Travel between the Prima Plana and the Abyss is one way: through death in the Prima Plana. Destruction of the material body and the performance of the appropriate burial rites allow the individual's soul to break through the barrier and enter the Abyss at its weakest point: the Valley of Darkness.

It is possible to leave the Abyss and enter the Prima Plana, however. This requires immense power, much of which is lost in the process. The exact method is the most guarded secret in the universe, but it is known to the most powerful beings. In order to enter the Prima Plana from the Abyss, an enormous amount of power must be expended, and there is great cost to both the sender and the sent (they cannot be the same one; that is one cannot send oneself through the barrier.) Once through to the Prima Plana, the being will have lost most of its power and be but a sliver of its former self. In order to return to the Abyss, the being must die, losing all its remaining power and being reduced to the most basic element: the stripped down soul. If it is to reclaim any of its former power, the soul must be rescued at the Valley of Darkness and nourished back to health through eons of existence. It is far more likely that the soul will be devoured by demons or enslaved by the Infernals, than be allowed to return to its former power. Given this

peril and difficulty, it is only in the most extreme circumstances that the voyage is attempted. However, given that the key (or entry) to Celestia is reputed to lie in the Prima Plana, the voyage is made.

It is known that Celestials have crossed only twice in recorded history. Their surviving numbers being so few, and their powers so highly restricted in the evil chaos of the Abyss, that they must pay a far greater price to undertake this course of action. It is for this reason that the practice of recruitment and creation of Saints as their primary agents to the world has been employed.

Infernals have crossed with more regularity, though typically it involves a high powered Warlord sending his personal minions to advance his plot or cause in the world. Infernals, more than any other, have interbred with as many species as possible and created thousands upon thousands of aberrations and mutations in attempts to strengthen their influence and position in the Prima Plana. The Infernals in the Abyss however, are not a unified force. They are a warring collection of thousands upon thousands of warlords and chieftains ruling over their own minions and plotting against one another. As a result, their servants and creations in the Prima Plana reflect this disorganisation.

Infernals, being fallen and corrupted Celestials, are not native to the Abyss, and so are likewise hamstrung in their power. Unlike the Celestials, who are considerably diminished in exile, the Infernals' very corruption has given them access to some of the power from the Abyss. They are still restricted, but not to the extent of the Celestials. In fact, desire for this power is one of the primary reasons a Celestial can fall and transform into an Infernal.

The native Demons of the Abyss, are an altogether different situation. They cross into the Prima Plana with far more regularity than either Celestials or Infernals. They still have a need to expend huge amounts of power and energy in order to break through the barrier, and they are still limited in returning (eg: they must still die in the Prima Plana in order for the soul to make it back to the Abyss.) However, demons are beings of pure chaos and evil. They are bent on total destruction and annihilation of all creatures and worlds, including their own. This is not to say that they are without intelligence, for some of the greater demons of the Abyss might be among the most intelligent creatures in the universe. But the desire to destroy is overwhelming and incomprehensible to mortals.

Demons are natives of the Abyss, and as such are in their full power in that realm. They wage total war against each other, and against the Infernals and Celestials. In this Abyssal War, the Celestials have managed to survive by hiding their kingdom well and fortifying their defenses. This has come at great cost, as only a relatively small handful of Celestials remain in existence. Infernals, on the other hand, are driven by the desire to conquer and rule. They seek to enslave all beings and dominate all worlds. This brings them into constant conflict with the marauding Demons of the Abyss.

The demons are enterprising and intelligent, as mentioned, if also chaotic and evil to an extreme. They expend great power to cross to the Prima Plana on hunting expeditions for the sheer gratification of causing as much damage and destruction as possible. They have also interbred and created plenty of aberrations and monstrosities in the world in order to further their chaos and destruction long after they have gone.

A spell cast on the Prima Plana that conjurs or summons a creature from the Abyss is not entirely what it appears to be. Such a summons merely calls an aspect (or reflection) of the being into the Prima Plana on a temporary basis. This aspect is far less powerful than its true form in the Abyss.

However, as with communications (see below) it would seem that it is somewhat easier and less expensive (in terms of energy and power spent) to truly summon a being in its True Form from the Abyss if the summons originates in the Prima Plana. It cannot be overemphasised that this type of summons involves the most powerful magic in the Prima Plana (even if it is lesser than what is required in the Abyss), and that the summoner himself will likely be destroyed in the process. While such summons of True outsiders have been performed throughout history, the result has been nothing short of cataclysmic. Those who insist on summoning creatures from the Abyss usually restrict themselves to summoning the less devastating aspects.

Travel to any of the elemental planes is impossible. These planes are composite parts of the Prima Plana as a whole. One cannot travel to these planes. One can, however, access their energy and material by emphasizing a particular element through the use of magical energy.

Travel to the Astral plane is, perhaps, the easiest and most common. It is unknown why this is, but even relatively low-powered magical spells and devices can access this plane. The Temporal Plane, however, is not physical in any way and as such cannot be visited. It is pure energy, and a bizarre and incomprehensible energy at that. Some extremely potent magical spells can access aspects of this plane, but only in terms of moving the energy forward, never backwards or stopping it. (Eg: a spell that appears to stop time is not stopping time at all, but rather speeding up the caster and moving him forward in space and time to such a degree that he appears to have stopped time relative to all other events.)

Communication between the planes is possible, though extremely difficult. The Astral and Temporal planes lend themselves to magical communication between the Abyss and the Prima Plana quite readily. (Celestia, appropriately, is silent.) Communication, however, is extremely difficult and involves the expenditure of a great deal of energy and power. This high cost usually restricts things to vital communications only, and even then the results are often cryptic dreams and omens. Admittedly, it seems to be easier to communicate from the Prima Plana to the Abyss than vice versa. That is, a powerful spellcaster has access to magic and spells that for a relatively low price might convey a clear message to a being in the Abyss. But the response from the Abyss is not so easily given. Many theories abound on why this is, but the most accepted explanation suggests that the chaotic nature of the Abyss makes any form of organised communication difficult.

Undeath

Undeath is the counterbalance to Life, and they exist in the world in equal proportions. However, equal proportions do not necessarily translate into equal numbers. The diversity and ubiquitousness of life reflects an equal diversity of undeath. There are some differences, since a large amount of what can be termed "lifeforms" in the world are aberrations and monstrosities that possess demonic or infernal blood. The Relationship between Undeath and the Abyss is an extremely complicated one, given the qualities of a

soul. The realms of Life and Undeath (or Unlife as some would have it) exist in parallel, often intermingling with one another in terrible ways.

Some noted scholars claim that for every life form and undead form also exists. By this argument, every fly and worm and squirrel has its own undead counterpart in existence somewhere. This antiquated theory has recently fallen into dispute as new sciences and methodologies have failed to prove the existence of such ridiculous forms of undeath.

The newest theory being advanced suggests that Undeath compensates for a lack of numbers with power. Life, by its very nature is fertile, creative and abundant. It is its basic characteristic that bountiful diversity of Life exists. Undeath is the opposite, being barren, destructive and stagnant. Where Life survives through rapid reproduction and expansion of numbers, Undeath survives by consolidating (or concentrating) immense power in a few beings: the fewer the number of undead, the more powerful the remaining ones, theoretically, become. Given the abundance of ghosts, zombies, skeletons, etc, there seems to be no worry just yet of a world-conquering Lich emerging any time soon if this theory proves correct.

The Soul

It is difficult to define the soul, or even identify it. Religion, superstition, philosophy, history and even science maintain that the soul can best be defined as the energetic magical essence that composes one half of a "being", along with the material body. Many questions and theories surround this assumption, but for lack of a better explanation, the Theory of Halves remains the most accepted one.

What happens to the soul at death? There are two possibilities, as stated in the dogma of the Saintly Faith. If a person is pious and worthy, and the proper burial rites are performed upon death, then the Soul breaks through the barrier and arrives at the gate of the Abyss: the Valley of Darkness, where the soul will be guided by one of the saints to the secluded fortress of Celestia-in-Exilio. The second possibility is that if the person does not follow the Saintly Faith and/or the proper funeral rites were not performed upon death, the soul is condemned to existence as an undead in the world. The absence of life through death results in undeath. The resulting soul can be trapped in a rotting corpse or released to haunt the world as a spirit or ghost. Countless theories and explanations exist surrounding this point and the philosophy of undeath.

A third possibility has recently emerged in the theories of the subversive Humanist philosophers and scientists. This Theory of Man suggests that humanity's central place at the core of all existence affords it the choice of oblivion. Beyond the Abyss and undeath, they state that the true result of death is the oblivion of both the body and the soul. The material body dissolves and dissipates into the material world over time, and likewise, the energetic soul dissolves and dissipates into the energetic world over time. It is only by foolish choice that one condemns oneself and enters into the Abyss as a follower of the Saintly Faith, or by circumstance that one is trapped in the world as undead.

Needless to say, the Humanist theory is regarded as blasphemy and heresy in the highest.